
TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

Programming Language Popularity Rankings and Trends

AUDIENCE

Tech Strategists

DATE

March 2026

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

TIOBE Index March 2026

KEY INSIGHT

Python leads but loses ground; C gains momentum and the top 4 languages still control nearly half the market.

Dominant Lead vs. Growth Trajectory

- Python maintains a dominant lead (**21.25%**), more than double the rating of second-place C (11.55%).
- Despite holding the top spot, Python recorded the largest year-over-year decline among the top 5 (**-2.59%**).
- C demonstrated significant momentum, gaining **+2.02%** year-over-year and surging to #2.
- The top 4 languages—Python, C, C++, and Java—concentrate **nearly 49%** of the total index.

Mar 2026	Mar 2025	Change	Programming Language	Ratings	Change
1	1		 Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	4	▲	 C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	2	▼	 C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	3	▼	 Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	5		 C#	6.36%	+1.69%
6	6		 JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	9	▲	 Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	8		 SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	16	▲	 R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	10		 Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	-0.39%
11	24	▲	 Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	12		 Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	11	▼	 Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	14		 Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	15		 MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	7	▼	 Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	17		 Assembly language	1.29%	+0.42%
18	13	▼	 PHP	1.23%	-0.25%
19	18	▼	 Ada	1.10%	+0.25%
20	26	▲	 Swift	1.04%	+0.44%

KEY INSIGHT

Legacy languages Perl and R show surprising resilience, while Go suffers its sharpest decline, falling out of the top 10.

Notable Gainers

Perl

Jumped from 24th to 11th

+1.05%
YoY

R

Climbed from 16th to 9th

+0.94%
YoY

Swift

Rose from 26th to 20th

+0.44%
YoY

Notable Losers

Go

Dropped sharply from 7th to 16th

-1.49%
YoY

C++

Dropped from 2nd to 3rd

-2.90%
YoY

Java

Fell from 3rd to 4th

-2.37%
YoY

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted

TIOBE Index March 2026

KEY INSIGHT

Python took 25 years to reach #1, while C remained the only constant top-2 language across four decades of measurement.

Programming Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	-	-
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	-	-
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	-	-	-
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	-	-
Visual Basic	7	6	11	-	-	-	-	-	-
Delphi/Object Pascal	8	185	12	12	9	-	-	-	-
SQL	9	10	-	-	-	-	-	-	-
Go	10	11	60	16	-	-	-	-	-
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2
(Visual) Basic	-	-	-	6	6	4	3	3	4

Python's Ascent

Unranked before 1991, entered top 30 in 2001, and reached #1 in 2018.

C's Resilience

The only language to remain in the top 2 across all nine 5-year intervals.

Java's Long Decline

Dominated from roughly 2005 to 2018, but has steadily fallen to under 8%.

Legacy Shifts

Lisp fell from #2 in 1986 to 26th; Ada peaked at 3rd and now sits at 14th.

Source: TIOBE Programming Community Index, March 2026

Time intervals measured every 5 years from 1986 to 2026.

KEY INSIGHT

Python's historical momentum is unmatched, but recent C# wins suggest shifting tides in the .NET ecosystem.

Hall of Fame Highlights

- Python has secured the "Language of the Year" award **six times** (2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, 2024), establishing an unmatched record.
- **C# won recently in 2023 and 2025**, driven by the continued growth of the .NET ecosystem across platforms.
- C++ captured the award in 2022, and C took it in 2019.
- Go's win in 2016 preceded its recent decline, highlighting that past momentum does not guarantee future dominance.

Year	Winner
2025	C#
2024	Python
2023	C#
2022	C++
2021	Python
2020	Python
2019	C
2018	Python
2017	C
2016	Go
2015	Java
2014	JavaScript
2013	Transact-SQL
2012	Objective-C
2011	Objective-C
2010	Python
2009	Go
2008	C
2007	Python
2006	Ruby
2005	Java
2004	PHP
2003	C++

KEY INSIGHT

Diversify hiring and tooling; while a few languages dominate, significant shifts indicate emerging legacy and performance trends.



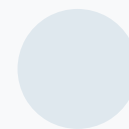
Python's Trajectory

Still dominant, but losing ground YoY. Teams should track its plateau and evaluate if its ecosystem covers all emerging AI needs.



C's Resurgence

Indicates sustained relevance for systems and performance-critical applications, contrasting with the rise of higher-level languages.



Legacy Revival

Perl, Fortran, and R prove their entrenched value in specialized domains (data analysis, scientific computing).



Concentration Risk

48.97% of ratings belong to Python, C, C++, and Java—highlighting the risks of over-indexing on narrow tech stacks.